

Incredible Health

As a young adult, Iman Abuzeid had planned to become a practicing physician. Her Sudanese parents had moved to Saudi Arabia—where Abuzeid was born—for her father’s job as an ear, nose, and throat surgeon. With her two older brothers also pursuing surgical careers, it was safe to say medicine was a family business. But when Abuzeid completed her medical degree at University College London in 2009, she knew her goal was to improve one-on-one patient care at scale, and she wasn’t sure she could accomplish that in private practice. “I always wanted to make an impact [at the] system level,” she said. “Patient care is amazing, but it’s not very scalable.” (Raz 2020)

Her dream became a reality in 2017 when she and her business partner launched Incredible Health, a healthcare job network, with a plan to alleviate nursing shortages by making it easier for qualified nurses to find jobs and manage their careers.

Background

Rather than completing her residency (a necessary step for her medical career), Abuzeid decided to move to the U.S. and pursue a Masters of Business Administration (MBA) at Wharton, the business school at the University of Pennsylvania. When she completed her MBA, she moved to San Francisco to work at a healthcare tech startup, AliveCor, where she met Rome Portlock, an MIT graduate and software engineer. She built her leadership and teamwork skills there, collaborating with software engineers, designers, and data scientists.

The longer Abuzeid lived in the U.S. the more she understood about the healthcare system, the understaffing in hospitals, and the looming nursing shortage.

“I have many family members and friends that are doctors and surgeons, and they [are] often complaining about understaffing,” she said. “And then at the same time my cofounder Rome has many family members that are nurses, and they’re saying, ‘I apply to 10 places and I don’t even hear back even though I’m experienced and I’m qualified.’ So, we figured there has to be a better way.” (Good Morning America 2022)

The Opportunity

Nurses and other health care professionals typically pursue jobs the same way most others do: by going to job fairs, making connections, applying to a host of potential employers, and hoping to get noticed. Abuzeid’s research found that on average, it took a hospital 82 days to find and hire a new nurse (Stanton 2022), in part because sorting through qualifications for various specialties was a tedious, manual undertaking. The process was both time consuming for hospitals that needed staffing and frustrating for nurses who experienced long wait times for interviews.

It was an unusual situation. In many industries, employers have the advantage of a large pool of applicants and relatively few openings, so they can afford to take their time hiring, and applicants feel lucky when they get an interview. But this market was the opposite: There were many more “buyers” (hospitals and clinics) than “sellers” (nurses). As a result, hospitals and clinics were spending a lot of time and money looking for nurses with specific qualifications and not finding them.

Abuzeid’s insight flipped the model. She wanted to create a platform on which health care organizations marketed themselves to nurses, who could then choose the best fit from among the opportunities.

She and Portlock created an algorithm that could sort nursing needs according to 70 different specializations, making it possible to match nurses to the positions for which they were best qualified, thus eliminating a burden on human resources departments. Likewise, the platform greatly streamlined the application process for nurses, who no longer experienced the challenges of navigating various job boards and slow response times.

Incredible Health wasn’t the only tech startup entering the market. Around the same time it launched, rivals like Trusted Health, Nomad, and Vivian Health all launched with a similar goal of using technology platforms to improve healthcare recruiting; however, these rivals focused primarily on short-term or traveling-nurse placements. Other more established rivals, like Indeed and LinkedIn, continued to provide job boards but not the same level of screening and matching.

No one was doing exactly what Incredible Health was: putting nurses in control of their job search and helping them find permanent, well-paying employment.

Results

Incredible Health offered hospitals a drastic reduction in hiring time—from about 12 weeks down to two, which would save about \$2 million in hiring-related costs per hospital (Stanton 2022). After analyzing these hiring patterns and cost savings, Abuzeid and Portlock recognized that hospitals were best aligned with this value proposition. They made the strategic decision to charge hospitals a subscription fee based on their hiring volume, while keeping the service free for nurses.

Abuzeid and Portlock had no idea how timely their entry into the market would be. While the nursing shortage was a problem in 2017, the COVID-19 pandemic accelerated it. In 2021, after a year of stress on healthcare systems, more than 100,000 registered nurses left the workforce (Health Affairs 2024). Many of the remaining nurses were getting close to retirement, with 25% expected to exit the workforce by 2025 (Stanton 2022).

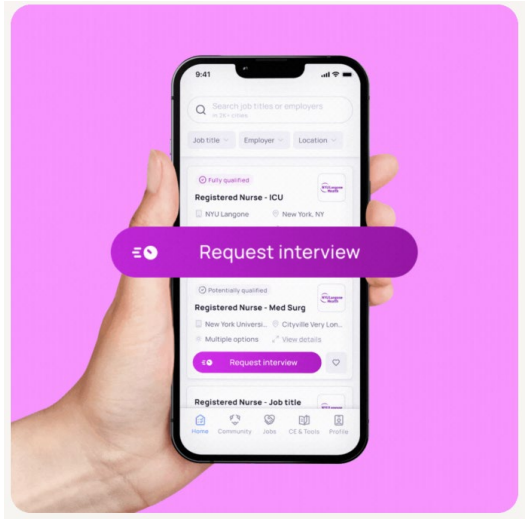


Figure 1. Incredible Health’s interviewing made easy

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To meet this growing demand caused by the pandemic, Abuzeid and Portlock decided to improve the platform by adding interview scheduling (Figure 1) and remote interview capabilities. They also added free continuing education for nurses.

Higher demand for the platform made Incredible Health attractive to investors. In 2022, the platform had 600 hospitals signed up and paying subscription fees and 10,000 nurses joining each week. These successes and increased traffic to their platform allowed the founders to raise \$80 million in additional funding, bringing the company’s valuation to \$1.65 billion (Stanton 2022).

As more hospitals and nurses joined the platform, the matching algorithms got better, and the team continued to enhance the product. In 2023, Incredible Health announced that it was using generative AI to improve a variety of features, including helping nurses create high-quality resumes, aiding recruiters to craft messages tailored to candidates, and processing applications more efficiently.

By the end of 2024, Incredible Health had served over 1,500 hospitals and 1 million nurses, and Abuzeid was well established as an entrepreneur in the medical field, making the impact she had dreamed of when she left medical school.

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